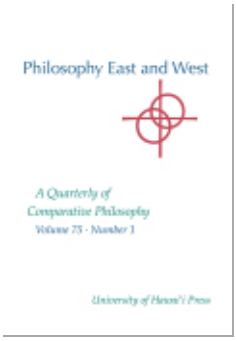
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Global Philosophy, Positionality, and Non-Relativist Perspectivism



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GLOBAL PHILOSOPHY, POSITIONALITY, AND NON-RELATIVIST PERSPECTIVISM



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I. Post-Comparative Global Philosophy and the Question of Positionality

In the course of the last two decades, as "comparative philosophy" (or its variant "world philosophy") has found some more institutional recognition in some more quarters of academic philosophy, it has also taken up new momentum, not least by floating new vocabulary describing the very substance and purpose of the endeavor. Such philosophy, and philosophy as such, is today supposed to be "global," "cosmopolitan," "fusion," or "post-comparative," and (to avoid the problem of having recognized philosophy determine what should be recognized as philosophy) also "interdisciplinary." The intention is not only to have a more global scope in what counts as philosophy, which might constitute a purely definitional or technical matter, but also—taking up discussions from post- and decolonial as well as feminist debates centered around the power/knowledge nexus—to be epistemically and politically more inclusive of different standpoints.

In some way, the inclusion of other philosophies has featured at the core of much earlier comparative philosophy, for better or worse. Born in the age of nineteenth-century colonialism, comparative philosophy has variously served imperialist agendas about the superiority of all things European but also fueled counterhegemonic projects. Over time, early colonial stereotypes of "non-European philosophy" have been self-assertively flipped into manifestations of the superiority of all things non-European. Meanwhile, the relation between comparative philosophy and place, belonging, and attachment has always been a troubled one. Countless practitioners of comparative philosophy have framed their endeavor as including a philosophical standpoint somehow taken to represent their "own tradition" and juxtaposing it to another philosophical standpoint somehow not their "own" (Weber 2013, pp. 4–5). Setting purely instrumentalist (and exoticizing) versions aside, most comparative philosophy therefore almost of necessity has been concerned with working across and mediating different philosophical standpoints. So, what has changed? In more recent decades, recognition has grown of the importance to conceive of that philosophical standpoint self-reflexively and

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critically in terms of it being tied to or even straightforwardly commensurate with a social and political standpoint. Whereas earlier works had been quick to turn any treatment of, say, a text like the *Mengzi* 孟子 into "the Chinese view," the standpoints invoked in works of comparative philosophy today are more multilayered, taking into account a host of political aspects such as blocked versus privileged access to the institutions of philosophy (journals, departments, etc.), the dominance of English-language scholarship, and questions of epistemic injustice, of gender or class at the individual, group, or global levels.

Comparative philosophy and its new avatars are faced today not only with a pluralization of philosophical standpoints but also with political settings and challenges that cannot always be easily detached from philosophy "as such," but that span across the whole spectrum of the power/knowledge nexus. Even an attempt to think of a comparative philosophy without borders cannot do without borders, but of necessity erects new borders as it tears down others. What emerges in this situation of the pluralization of philosophical standpoints might be expressed as follows: "Good creative philosophy in a globalized world should spontaneously straddle geographical areas and cultures, temperaments and time-periods (mixing classical, medieval, modern, and postmodern), styles and subdisciplines of philosophy, as well as mix methods, sprinkling phenomenology, and political economic analysis into analytic logicolinguistic or hermeneutic, or culture studies or literary or narrative methods – whatever comes handy. The result would be either very flaky mishmash or first-rate original work" (Chakrabarti and Weber 2015, p. 22). Elsewhere we write: "When a post-fusion philosopher, keeping Kant's categorical imperative as well as Hindu and Buddhist ethics in mind, considers what is the source of normativity in the imperative prohibition 'You should not kill or be cruel to another human being or yourself,' they would be doing just philosophy, hopefully tapping into more than one philosophical tradition for their intuition pumps" (Chakrabarti and Weber 2023, p. 171). But philosophizing across such wide-ranging mixtures of sources brings up the question of what happens to the emphasis on standpoint, inasmuch as philosophizing with, for example, Kant includes a particular standpoint (occupied by Kant, the Kantian tradition, one's reading of Kant and that tradition, etc.). Does straddling across sources mean neglecting the importance of standpoint? Or would giving due importance to standpoint not frustrate any attempt to square Kant's categorical imperative with Hindu and Buddhist ethics, even to square Hindu and Buddhist ethics (the "Indian view") in the first instance? To what extent is a de-emphasizing standpoint perhaps necessary to make the (post)-comparative exercise possibly fruitful? Or put differently: how to mediate the emphasis on globality (viz., a more "global" philosophy) with the insistence of the importance of standpoints (viz., a more "inclusive" philosophy)—or, what seems to me, a different word for the same point, positionality?

II. Positionality and Perspective as an Enabling Condition and a Restraining Factor

The term "globality" is largely positively connoted—unlike "globalization," which for many today sounds merely imperialist in disguise and which finds itself currently challenged by tendencies of "deglobalization," and unlike "globalism," which denotes the ideological, if not conspiracy-theory-version of globalization. Globality stands independently of these terms. It denotes a condition, that of being global; the "-ity"-ending typically emphasizes the state, quality, or behavior of the adjective. It has increasingly become a term of choice for "a figure of thought" (Kühnhardt and Mayer 2019) in many quarters of the humanities and social sciences, even if it is not yet a central term by any count. In many ways, globality is an easy choice since it seems to evade longstanding and complicated feuds between those defending either universality or particularity/singularity and, relatedly, either universalism or relativism. "Globality" is sometimes paired with "locality," but the two terms are rarely presented as mutually exclusive. With regard to global knowledge production, globality may refer to a factual or normative condition. There is the fact of global knowledge production, its reality so-to-say, which might accumulate to a low or high level, but discussions are often concerned normatively about enabling *a more global* knowledge production or achieving *a more truly global* knowledge production.

There is a persistent belief in many parts of academia that the inclusion of more perspectives tied to different positionalities helps ensure more globality. A perspective is valuable, is a contribution because it gives voice to a different positionality. Often, today, and understandably so, the discourse is about the inclusion of "Southern" perspectives, say, of African, Latin American, or Asian perspectives—which, of course, is already a way of putting it that invokes the "North" or "Europe" as that which has hitherto been unjustly "exclusive" (in both senses of the term). There is certainly an important political dimension to this discourse, perhaps one on the relevance and persistence of epistemic injustice, which would deserve its own rightful discussion. My concern, however, is not that discussion and also not these horrendous referents often mentioned: African, Latin American, and European (the level of abstraction is mind-boggling), but more fundamentally, my concern is about a certain epistemological move underlying this belief.

Epistemologically, the question that interests me is what one claims when one says that more perspectives from more positionalities would ensure more globality, as in "a more global knowledge" or "more globally informed knowledge." How exactly is this so? Are there variants we could, or perhaps should, distinguish? In philosophy, this question may translate, *mutatis mutandis*, into the doctrine of perspectivism. Take the Spanish (!) philosopher Ortega y Gasset. In his writings, he emphasized that from different positions, two people see the same surroundings, but (in Dobson's paraphrase) "they do not see the same thing. Their different positions mean that the surroundings are organized in a

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different way: what is in the foreground for one may be in the background for another. Furthermore, as things are hidden one behind another, each person will see something that the other may not" (Dobson 1989, pp. 144–145). For Ortega y Gasset, the implication of perspectivism is not that the other's view is false, but simply that there cannot be a view exhaustively including all of the surrounding and therefore no reality that would look the same from any point of view. He famously concludes that "perspective is one of the components of reality" and "far from being its deformation, it is its organization" (trans. Dobson, original in Ortega y Gasset 1955, p. 199).[1]

Earlier, Friedrich Nietzsche had laid the ground for perspectivism as a philosophy, variously treating of truth, epistemic, and other perspectivisms, which it is not easy to combine into one unified theory (Hales and Welshon 1994, pp. 101–103). In a passage of *The Genealogy of Morals*, Nietzsche upholds that there "is *only* a perspective seeing, *only* a perspective knowing; and the *more* affects we allow to speak about one thing, the *more* eyes, different eyes, we can use to observe one thing, the more complete will our 'concept' of this thing, our 'objectivity' be" (Nietzsche 1989, p. 119).[2] Importantly, and somewhat in contradistinction to Ortega y Gasset, Nietzsche here appears to add up perspectives straightforwardly epistemically, perhaps not conclusively, but meaningfully; if not, then at least it can be argued with Hales (2020, p. 28) that while for Nietzsche "diverse perspectives generate distinct kinds of knowledge," he also adopts a second-order perspectivism holding that an appreciation of all these diverse perspectives allows for a "richer sort of understanding." More perspectives thus seem to translate into more completeness (of knowledge or of understanding). Just in case, it is against this background easy to carve out a simple distinction between a nonadditive, more relativist perspectivism claiming that reality quintessentially includes perspective (there is no reality beyond perspective) and an additive, more perfectionist perspectivism claiming that more perspectives, because of their greater number and content, give a more complete picture (there is a reality beyond perspective). If the latter, that is, perfectionist perspectivism, is to make sense, what does the addition of one perspective to another exactly do? How does this adding up of perspectives actually work?

To delve further into these questions, I want to revisit very briefly two stories and then draw a provisory conclusion from them. One story comes from Argentinian (!) author Jorge Luis Borges. His "Funes el memorioso" tells the story of a man named Funes, who, we are told, is incapable of Platonic ideas, of generalities, of abstraction; his world is one of intolerably uncountable details. Because he has perfect memory, he remembers and knows everything about everything that he ever encounters. When Funes looks at what others would consider as one and the same dog "at three-fourteen (seen in profile)" and "at three-fifteen (seen from the front)," Jorge Luis Borges makes the point that Funes is actually seeing two completely different dogs. For Funes, there is in fact nothing like one and the same thing. The other story comes in many forms

originally from India (!). It is the parable of the blind men and the elephant. Here it is in the nineteenth-century American (!) poet John Godfrey Saxe's version (1873, pp. 259–261), historically a version that helped popularize the parable to a more global audience beyond India:

I.

It was six men of Indostan / To learning much inclined, / Who went to see the Elephant / (Though all of them were blind), / That each by observation / Might satisfy his mind.

II.

The *First* approached the Elephant, / And happening to fall / Against his broad and sturdy side, / At once began to bawl: / "God bless me! – but the Elephant / Is very like a wall!"

III.

The *Second*, feeling of the tusk, / Cried: "Ho! – what have we here / So very round and smooth and sharp? / To me 't is mighty clear / This wonder of an Elephant / Is very like a spear!"

IV.

The *Third* approached the animal, / And happening to take / The squirming trunk within his hands, / Thus boldly up and spake: / "I see," quoth he, "the Elephant / Is very like a snake!"

V.

The *Fourth* reached out his eager hand, / And felt about the knee. / "What most this wondrous beast is like / Is mighty plain," quoth he; / "'T is clear enough the Elephant / Is very like a tree!"

VI.

The *Fifth*, who chanced to touch the ear, / Said: "E'en the blindest man / Can tell what this resembles most; / Deny the fact who can, / This marvel of an Elephant / Is very like a fan!"

VII.

The *Sixth* no sooner had begun / About the beast to grope, / Than, seizing on the swinging tail / That fell within his scope, / "I see," quoth he, "the Elephant / Is very like a rope!"

VIII.

And so these men of Indostan / Disputed loud and long, / Each in his own opinion / Exceeding stiff and strong, / Though each was partly in the right, / And all were in the wrong!

MORAL

So, oft in theologic wars / The disputants, I ween, / Rail on in utter ignorance / Of what each other mean, / *And prate about an Elephant / Not one of them has seen!*

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There are also Jain and Buddhist versions of this story, and even Leo Tolstoy contributed a version. Both Borges's "Funes el memorioso" and this parable are in a way about perspectivism. But they stand in some respect, at least at first glance, at opposite ends. Funes sees apparently all as it is; the men in the parable are blind and, missing one sense, come to mistake everything. The radical opposition of these views might help reveal distinctions leading to different variants of perspectivism.

Funes sees everything perfectly, taking in every little detail, always from the most singular perspective. But, crucially, he cannot overcome singularity. Talk of "detail" in this context does not make much sense. In the story, he is fashioned as seeing two and, by consequence, even innumerable dogs, whereas less perfect memoriosos see only one dog. Yet, importantly, for him, nothing adds up. No grammatical plural is available to him, and neither are singular nouns. For although he knows everything, he would not know what *a* dog is. He couldn't possibly have a word for "dog." He would live in a world of purely proper names, one proper name for each perspective that he deploys. It seems he would simply perceive a series of wide shots, each moment a singular image, only restricted by the physical limits of his eyes, only seeing a snippet at any one point in time. For it is far from clear that he would be able, as the story claims he is, to perceive distinctions, for he cannot think any abstract regard against which a distinction would arise. And, turning the title of the story on its head, he is not capable of remembering. Funes is not a memorioso at all. In any case, the perspectivism that Funes embodies in the story is presented as one that does not constrain; quite the contrary, it maximally if most unproductively (and humanly quite unbearably) enables.

The blind man's is literally a constrained perspective. But does it add up nonetheless? Obviously not for them, since what they perceive is a snake, a wall, and so on. Yet mind that for the non-blind in the parable (in some versions a king is involved who has "an elephant" brought in front of the blind men), there is no doubt that the blind men are touching parts of "an elephant." Saxe's version of the parable has an important line that suggests an adding-up version: "*Though each was partly in the right*." And is it not so? A leg of an elephant is "like" a tree, the trunk "like" a snake, the tusk "like" a spear, and so on. Indian (!) philosopher Bimal Matilal, when discussing mistaking a rope for a snake as an example of perceptual illusion, emphasizes how there must be some sufficient similarity of properties, features, and aspects for a misperception to occur: "I cannot mistake a mustard seed for an elephant" (Matilal 1986, p. 203). So would not all of these elements combined (in a long chain of analogies) eventually make one beautiful elephant? In the version of the parable told by the nineteenth-century Indian Mystic Sri Ramakrishna, a passerby hears of the blind men's quarrel, and after they give him each their accounts, Ramakrishna makes him respond: "Not one of you knows the real elephant. As a whole, it is neither like a pillar, nor a jar, nor a winnowing fan, nor a club. But its legs are like pillars, its belly like a big jar, its ears like a winnowing fan, and its trunk like a thick club. The elephant

itself is a combination of all these." For Ramakrishna, the morale of the parable pertains to how, in religious dispute, each contending faction has merely seen "some different aspect of the Deity" (Ramakrishna and Abhedānanda 1907, pp. 28–29).

Surely, in this more comprehensive sense, the parable is perhaps not about the blind men and their restrained perspective only, but also about those non-blind who think that they know that they see an elephant. And the real question thus becomes whether the story would be any different, if the blind men were not blind but seeing, or whether the parable finally puts up a sort of Plato's cave analogy. To draw a provisory conclusion, it is unclear how an adding up of perspectives would work in the case of this parable, particularly if every perspective is lacking in some regard (for a trunk of an elephant *is* not a snake, but only "like" a snake, i.e., it shares some aspects, is similar in some regards, but not in others). It is this constraint that comes with having a perspective that is at the core of the parable. The perspectives of the blind men are different because they touch different parts of the elephant, but they are not unique or singular. If one blind man came to touch the different parts one after the other, he might still claim to have touched a tree, a snake, and a spear, just like the others did.

The idea of how adding more perspectives would be a move toward a more complete "concept" or more "objectivity" might rest on an idealized version of how different perspectives relate to each other and would simply fit each other in combination (rather than stand in an indissoluble contradiction, for instance). For a perfect addition, something like a jigsaw puzzle would be required. Yet, often, in discussions of global philosophy, it is less a question of combining elements of an elephant into an organic whole, but rather that one discussant takes the trunk to be a snake, while the other claims *it* to be a rope.

To the extent that positionality is akin to having a perspective, one might conclude that disposing of a certain positionality is always and necessarily an enabling and a constraining condition. The inclusion of more perspectives tied to different positionalities, it seems, does not necessarily have to ensure more globality in the sense—pace Nietzsche—of achieving more complete concepts or more objectivity. Positionality, to the extent that it expresses a singular and exalted perspective, might even stand in the way of reaching more globality. This is not to say that adding perspectives is not helpful. But the simple presumption that an adding-up account would necessarily ensure such an outcome is overly simplistic. Distinguishing versions of perspectivism and what they mean for globality as a normative condition is therefore relevant to contemporary discussions on global knowledge production, including in (post-)comparative philosophy. First, some popular but reductionist versions of decolonial theory are tilted toward portraying European perspectives and positionality as only or mostly constraining (the blind men of Eurocentrism), whereas Southern, non-European perspectives are presented as only or mostly enabling positionalities (seeing the elephant in the room, as it were). Second,

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it is unclear how the emphasis on globality that goes with highlighting the importance of positionality actually bodes with the other dominant discourse in the field, the one on relational epistemologies. Emphasizing relationality, it appears, implies the rejection of all perspectivisms that rely on the strict importance of singularity.

Against this background, positionality might not in the first instance be about seeing more of "it" (as in perfectionist perspectivism), but seeing "it" from more, from different, possibly from radically different sides (without the epistemologically damaging consequences of relativist perspectivism). The importance of positionality lies partly in epistemology, in as much as the attempt to retrieve or take up other perspectives may function as a necessary corrective to any one positionality, a difference-generator or "intuition pump," partly in helping to navigate the knowledge–politics nexus in a way that reduces the risk of simply or blindly following an easy geography (Asia, Europe, etc.), as it might also function as a detector of the sociology and politics that go with philosophy. Even relational approaches can profit from the inclusion of positionalities that lead beyond and challenge the relational framework at hand.

III. The Example of Sovereignty

Global post-comparative philosophy as "just" philosophy is about valuing philosophical difference, irrespective of from where and by whom the position is articulated (Chakrabarti and Weber 2023). Yet, to the extent that the past of institutionalized philosophy has tended to reproduce power asymmetries, "just" philosophy should also be about cleverly making previously marginalized positions heard, though in a manner that does not simply reverse the earlier epistemic exclusionary mechanisms and is maximally wary of continued and newly created power asymmetries. In this spirit, global post-comparative philosophy actively advocates for the inclusion of all sorts of perspectives and positionalities. In all of this, the successful mediation of emphasis on globality and positionality is key.

In previous works, I have tried to tackle the political concepts of AUTHORITY (Weber 2015) and REPRESENTATION (Weber 2021). With regard to the former, I mix a logical (Bochenski), a Rome-focused conceptual history (Eschenburg), and a phenomenological (Kojève) approach and add several layers of crisscrossing discussions. One of these draws on a much-commented episode between Russell and Wittgenstein that I examine as an example of Frickerian epistemic injustice. Another turns on the issue of the authority of number on the basis of passages from the *Han Feizi* 韩非子 and the *Guanzi* 管子. With regard to the latter, the perspectives informing the discussion are drawn from Leon Trotsky, from ancient Near Eastern and Chinese terminology, from a text by Yuri Pines on early China, from short references to Laclau and Schumpeter, quite extensively from the Federalists and Antifederalists' famous debate, from a history of idea contribution fleshing out early French and English

views (Philip Manow), from a philosophy of mind French-discourse contribution (Pierre Guenancia), and from a longer treatment of seventeenth-century Confucian thinker Huang Zongxi and his *Mingyi daifang lu* 明夷待訪錄. In light of this previous work, some questions might arise: What exactly happens when such widespread positions are mixed into what is supposed to be one coherent philosophical discussion? Do the different elements deserve different emphasis of their positionality? Is this an issue of mediating the global inclusion motifs forming part of my positionality with the positionality of the elements drawn into the discussion, hence a question of hermeneutics? Could all of the above simply be summarized without much loss as an exercise of comparative philosophy between East and West, Europe and China? Would not the very attempt at mixing undermine any effort of keeping the *comparanda* intact?

When giving an "Afterword" to our *Comparative Philosophy without Borders*, Arindam Chakrabarti contributed a list of questions that any good fusion philosopher would have to consider:

- How much history of ideas will be necessary or sufficient for good fusion thinking?
- How much text-interpretation will be required?
- How much ahistorical original conceptual creativity will be necessary?
- How much resemblance-discovery should be aimed for?
- How much contrast-discovery is essential?
- How to achieve a balance between giving rigorous, clear arguments and being contemplatively authentic and phenomenologically descriptive? (Chakrabarti and Weber 2015, p. 234).

These questions mirror a specific philosophical subset in the mediating task between globality as a stated aim, the positionality of oneself, and the materials one draws on. A similar subset of questions, more specifically representative of the power/knowledge nexus, could easily be fancied. All of these questions, more importantly, point toward tensions, perhaps even irreconcilabilities between possible answers. If these questions stand for philosophical positions (e.g., history of ideas vs. ahistorical original conceptual creativity), then it is obvious that neither a relativist nor an additive model of perspectivism can possibly drive such an endeavor; even a moderately perfectionist model seems ill-placed to accommodate the practice of global post-comparative philosophy exhaustively.

Turning to a fresh example, that is, the concept of SOVEREIGNTY, I want to examine how some elements come to be included in the first place and how they more exactly relate to each other as candidates for a joint philosophical discussion. Obviously, the candidates will either already be known to me or become known to me through the efforts in the inquiry. This would mean that I, given my own structural positionality and personal perspective, would begin my inquiry by looking into English (!) political philosopher Thomas Hobbes's

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take on sovereignty and its more recent histories in international law and in international relations theory. I would also try to take a hint from the word's etymology, leading me to French *souveraineté* and *le souverain*, to Latin *superanus*, which stands for "supreme, above," and be reminded of the theological interest in God, the Lord, being sovereign, understood as having supreme power over his creation. Mind that Hobbes's *Leviathan* is the "Mortall God." Inescapably, recent word usage, like the notion of "food sovereignty," would also be on my mind. Probably, quite early on, I would think of candidates in early Chinese texts that might speak to the concept of sovereignty, look at translations or discussions of literature on early Chinese texts that have used the word "sovereignty," and also check out how recent discussions in Chinese (!) intellectual discourse have talked about sovereignty (*zhuquan* 主权/*tongzhiquan* 统治权), for example, Wang Hui and his work on the rise of modern Chinese thought (Wang 2014; Wang 2023). At this initial stage, the process is decidedly eclectic and largely reflective of previous interests. Crucially, as the inquiry proceeds and a more coherent discussion emerges, these initial elements may prove instrumental to build a kind of background idea, a preconcept, that will steer whether and to what extent further yet to be discovered elements might be understood as being about sovereignty.

When thinking about sovereignty as a modern concept, Hobbes quickly becomes central, as he is one of the authors in whose texts we can witness the transition from the concept of a sovereign understood as a person in power to the concept of sovereignty, standing for a more abstract idea of supreme power. In a crucial passage, Hobbes defines the essence of his commonwealth (or state, or *civitas*) as constituted by "One Person, of whose Acts a great Multitude, by mutuall Covenants one with another, have made themselves every one the Author, to the end he may use the strength and means of them all, as he shall think expedient, for their Peace and Common Defence" (Hobbes 1996, p. 121). This Person, Hobbes refers to as the "SOVERAIGNE," said to have sovereign power, while everyone else is his or her subject.[3] Hobbes's imagery turns on the father figure (who conventionally, but not by nature, has sovereign power over his children and grandchildren) and the military victor (who has sovereign power over subdued enemies), but he famously also includes another way, resulting in a political commonwealth, "when men agree amongst themselves, to submit to some Man, or Assembly of men, voluntarily, on confidence to be protected by him against all others" (Hobbes 1996, p. 121). Hobbes's concession that the sovereign could be a "Man" or an "Assembly of men" is important, since it shows that "Person" might be referring to an individual or a group. The sovereign as Person is, in Hobbes's conception, necessarily an abstraction. The entire imagery of the *Leviathan* (a biblical sea monster) adds further to the abstraction that enters and transcends the more traditional idea of the sovereign as the ruler or lord with supreme power. Most conclusively in this context, perhaps (and illustrative of Kantorowicz and the early modern king's two bodies), is the practice of the effigies, which Horst Bredekamp

had shown Hobbes was certainly aware of, as they were well established in England at "ceremonial funerals and the subsequent commemoration of deceased monarchs" (Bredekamp 2020, p. 90). Bredekamp explicitly interprets the effigies as "a new means of visualizing a larger notion: that of sovereignty, albeit enacted in a sequence of separate reigns, as itself a continuum, even a testament to immortality" (Bredekamp 2020, p. 91). In *Leviathan*, Hobbes treats extensively of "Soveraigntie," of which he thinks there are but three kinds: monarchy, democracy, and aristocracy (Hobbes 1996, p. 129). Some people might consider more forms of sovereignty, Hobbes conjectures, such as forms "arising from these mingled together":

> … Elective Kingdomes; where Kings have the Soveraigne Power put into their hands for a time; of Kingdomes, wherein the King hath a power limited: which Governments, are nevertheless by most Writers called Monarchie. Likewise if a Popular, or Aristocraticall Common-wealth, subdue an Enemies Countrie, and govern the same, by a President, Procurator, or other Magistrate; this may seeme perhaps at first sight, to be a Democraticall, or Aristocraticall Government. But it is not so. For Elective Kings, are not Soveraignes, but Ministers of the Soveraigne; nor limited Kings Soveraignes, but Ministers of them that have the Soveraigne Power: Nor are those Provinces which are in subjection to a Democracie, or Aristocracie of another Common-wealth, Democratically, or Aristocratically governend, but Monarchically. (Hobbes 1996, p. 134)

Hobbes is already fully aware of the possibility of a democracy instituted with indivisible sovereignty, but sets out his argument for why he thinks a monarchy superior. And, as shown in the quoted passage above, he knows of other forms gleaned from "particular Common-wealthes that have been, and are in the world," such as having a king democratically elected for a time by the people, but points out that in such a system, the people remain the true sovereign. The idea of a divided sovereignty, as theories of mixed constitution and the division of power suggest, rests for Hobbes on a conceptual confusion. With Hobbes, we see the transition from the earlier personalized idea of the sovereign to a modern concept of abstract and (as Hobbes insisted against the parliamentary writers of his day) also "indivisible" sovereignty. Hobbes makes the point about abstraction explicitly in his dedicatory epistle to Francis Godolphin for the *Leviathan*, when he points out that he speaks "not of the men, but (in the Abstract) of the Seat of the Power" (Hobbes 1996, p. 3). Quentin Skinner explains that for Hobbes, "this seat is occupied not by any natural person or body of persons, but rather by the disembodied and fictional Person whose generic name is the State" (Skinner 2007, p. 178).[4]

Let us add a second element. If one approaches sovereignty as a concept of central importance to international law and international relations, something like the Hobbesian conception would be found to be lingering on. But through a variety of developments, mostly the continued significance of the theory of mixed constitution in liberal democracies (Riklin 2006), sovereignty has come

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to be understood—*contra* Hobbes—as divisible. This is perhaps most clearly the case in the contexts of the United Nations or the European Union, for who is the sovereign in the latter, say, the European Commission or any given member state of the European Union? Literature tracing the more recent developments of the concept of sovereignty in European history (Kalmo and Skinner 2010) or in global history (Howland and White 2009) comes to assert that sovereignty is not even a thing anymore but a mere abstraction. Even historically, the concept is so contingent as to frustrate any attempt at a definition that would do justice to this historical plurality. Therefore, these authors tell us, the best one can do is to study the different uses of the concept. At this point, we need not delve further into the discussion but can inquire into how this second element (divided sovereignty) would not be easily mixed with the first element (Hobbes's indivisible sovereignty) in what would be one discussion of SOVEREIGNTY. There are plenty of ways to link the two elements, by way of conceptual overlap (as necessarily an abstraction regardless of the issue of divisibility), by way of the use of the same word, by way of a development from indivisible sovereignty to divisible sovereignty in contemporary international law, and so forth. But there is also the possibility of linking two things by drawing a contrast, even a contrast regarding the very concept of SOVEREIGNTY. "Contrast-discovery" is a standard operation in comparative philosophy that functions by way of introducing a *tertium*, a certain respect in which a contrast is said to exist.

An altogether similar situation with regard to the possibility of linking arises when bringing, say, the *Han Feizi* into the picture. According to Yuri Pines, Han Fei was also concerned about the mediocrity of average individual rulers and therefore wanted to minimize their role in everyday decision-making, which made him emphasize all the more the institution of rulership. Han Feizi's ideal model of rulership rested on an "omnipotent and yet utterly depersonalized sovereign" (Pines 2013, p. 77) and what Pines calls "the nullification of the monarch" (Pines 2013, p. 79). Against this background, is it legitimate to read Han Fei's move to the depersonalization of the monarch as a Hobbes-like move from a sovereign to sovereignty—or perhaps rather the other way around, to read Hobbes as performing a Han Fei move from a sovereign ruler to state sovereignty? Would a positive answer to these questions, in some way, allow for an additive model of Hobbes and Han Fei? Perhaps in any case of an addition of their perspectives without prejudicing their positionalities? What if the question about the legitimacy of the move is answered negatively? Would that not mean to give more weight to the particularity, maybe even singularity, of Hobbes or Han Fei? In his time, Han Fei certainly did not react to parliamentarian writers who wanted to put the sovereignty of the people as a check against the power of the monarch. Some such difference can easily and always be found. Singularity-approaching particularity of necessity frustrates any attempt at purposeful comparison (Chakrabarti and Weber 2015, p. 9). If particularity is simply another term for acknowledgment of positionality, does that mean that positionality is emphasized with the implication of simply claiming a different

perspective that can no longer be simply included in an additive model of perspectivism? Does this also hold if the difference is but a contrast in regard to a shared regard, or would that amount to the possibility of addition at a more abstract level?

It is unclear how the possibility of addition could be determined by the nature of the elements to be added and would not depend essentially on the operations done by the fusion philosopher. While all too abstract addition might be pointless and a claim toward Funes-il-memorioso-like-radical difference go against the initial understanding that the Han Fei does somehow speak to the issue of sovereignty that Hobbes discusses (more an Asian and an African elephant than a mustard seed and an elephant), there seems to be a fair middle ground on the ladder of abstraction (for this, see Chakrabarti and Weber 2015, pp. 9–10) at which global post-comparative philosophers can make their own choices as to mix and claim similarity or contrast discovery.

IV. In Lieu of a Conclusion: Positionality as Perspective Reconsidered

Above, I have chosen to translate *mutatis mutandis*, the issue of positionality, into the philosophical problem of perspectivism and have treated the two terms largely as congruently. In lieu of a conclusion, I want to revisit this decision and examine whether it might be helpful to distinguish between occupying a positionality and having a perspective more clearly. I have gestured toward a possible distinction by referring in one of the above passages to "structural positionality and personal perspective." For one thing, positionality, like standpoint in feminist standpoint theory, is tied to the power–knowledge nexus in a way that perspective is not necessarily. Positionality also seems to emphasize characteristics (and therefore views) attributed to a group, whereas perspective tends to be more often related to individuals.

There are, however, very different perspectivisms. The story of "Funes el memorioso" presents the most radical version, where the perspective is so spectacularly enabling that all of Funes's many perfect perspectives do not add up to a perfect image of one object, since he is incapable of stably perceiving and keeping in his mind one and the same object. Yet, any other person with the same inhuman capabilities that Funes exhibits would have the same perfect perspectives and see exactly what Funes sees. There is behind the inhumanity of such a perfect memorioso no subject to begin with. The perspectivism of the Funes story is not subjectivist at all. Subjectivist versions of perspectivism are completely within the realm of the possible, but they also do not add up easily, even if for another reason. If every individual had a singular perspective because of strong subjectivism, then it would be unclear how any addition of such perspectives would reveal more about the object rather than about the plurality of subjects viewing the object.

There are also quite a variety of positionalities that can be distinguished. There is an individualist version that ascribes to every person a different

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positionality, which, however, is not subjectivist but objectivist, since any other individual in the same position would see the same thing if in that position. Amartya Sen has referred to this as "position-dependent objectivity" or "positional objectivity" (Sen 1993, p. 127). It is indeed quite conceivable how such positionalities could be combined into a fuller view, similar to Nietzsche's more complete "objectivity." But would all individuals and their positions have to be included? Would any selection of individuals short of everyone not open up the possibility of group bias?

Amartya Sen discusses the question of positionality in terms of objective beliefs (different from true beliefs), which might be shared with other persons in the community. Discussing morbidity perceptions in Kerala and Uttar Pradesh, Sen comes to explain that the positional objectivity of the views in question cannot be dismissed as "simply subjective," but the self-perceptions are also not "accurate" when held against "any trans-positional understanding" (Sen 1993, p. 135). Such transpositional "assessment" and "scrutiny" are much needed, according to Sen, "drawing on but going beyond different positional observations," which would allow for something like a "constructed 'view from nowhere'" based "on synthesizing different views from distinct positions" (Sen 1993, p. 130). Sen is quick to add that this would, however, "demand some kind of coherence between different positional views" (Sen 1993, p. 130).

Most relevant to comparative philosophy and the question of the addition of positionalities is Sen's treatment of cultural relativism. Culturally relativistic views can be understood as "objective" in the sense of positional objectivity, but Sen rejects the idea that there is only one "special set of positional parameters" available to members of a given society. There would always be "contrary views" and "internal criticism" in any society that would have to be heeded as equally internal: "The viewpoint of, say, the dominant clergy in Iran has no more privileged status in assessing 'the Iranian position' than that of one of the many dissenters," regardless of whether or not the views of the latter had been "influenced by their reading of foreign authors (such as Kant, Hume, Marx, or Mill)" (Sen 1993, pp. 139–140). Arguments in support of cultural relativism, Sen adds, "typically operate on units that are much too gross" (Sen 1993, p. 140).

Against this background, there is certainly an argument for a transpositional assessment of structurally different positionalities (and hence for inclusive practices in philosophy) and perhaps for a weak additive model, one far from perfectionist. But there are pitfalls, which come with such a model, that are not easy to avoid, such as the problem that structural positionality always seems to come with claims for representation and that "coherence between different positional views" is not just a given but dependent on the choices of the global post-comparative philosopher. The representation aspect is also not easily reconciled with a subjective perspectivist emphasis on the lived experience of the individual and on situated and embodied knowledge that is sometimes mixed into decolonial arguments, otherwise stressing structural

positionality. Structural positionality, it seems, claims epistemological value but also mends a political injustice.

Global post-comparative philosophy as just philosophy suggests that there is epistemological value in inclusive transpositional philosophical practices without sporting an easy but mistakenly strong additive model of perspectivism and of positionalities. Notably, the discussion offered above has itself drawn on a global, inclusive approach, mixing together positions from different philosophical standpoints, from persons conventionally introduced by their nationality (what does this convention actually do?), from different genres, including a short story, a parable, and so on. The example of sovereignty has further, if only very roughly, illustrated that philosophizing across positionalities requires the discretion of philosophers to choose whether or not they decide to mix together two elements in their philosophical work. Perhaps more like the five blind men and the elephant and less like Funes, philosophers have to conceptualize and draw up borders and distinctions, even in the effort to think of borderless philosophy.

Notes

1 – In the Spanish original: "La perspectiva es uno de los componentes de la realidad. Lejos de ser su deformación, es su organización."

2 – In the German original: "Es giebt nur ein perspektivisches Sehen, nur ein perspektivisches 'Erkennen'; und je mehr Affekte wir über eine Sache zu Worte kommen lassen, je mehr Augen, verschiedne Augen wir uns für dieselbe Sache einzusetzen wissen, um so vollständiger wird unser 'Begriff' dieser Sache, unsre 'Objektivität' sein."

3 – Hobbes, in *Leviathan*, despite the depiction on the frontispiece, is clear that the sovereign could be a man or a woman. In fact, he gestures to women as, in some cases, being more prudent and better suited than men to exercise dominion over others (see Skinner 2007, p. 175). For a relevant passage in *Leviathan*, concerning paternal dominion, see ch. 20: "And whereas some have attributed the Dominion to the Man onely, as being of the more excellent Sex; they misreckon in it. For there is not alwayes that difference of strength, or prudence between the man and the woman, as that the right can be determined without War" (see Hobbes 1996, p. 139).

4 – Skinner references David Runciman (2007), who has convinced him to refer to the state as being a "fiction" in Hobbes rather than an "artifice."

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